

Some of your utilities might have been transferred to your name by the title company at closing, but make sure you take care of any leftovers. If you forget to pay your new electricity bill for a week, they'll give you a little leeway. A month—not so much. Make sure your water, electricity, trash removal, and Wi-Fi are ready to go. You might want to change your mailing address while you're at it.

Within the first few days of moving in, you're going to want to change the locks so you're the only one with keys to the castle. If you're hopeless with tools, that's okay—it's easy to hire a handyman for this. The same goes for the opener and code for your garage door, if you have one.

Make sure you add fresh batteries to your smoke alarms. If you don't have smoke alarms, you're going to want some. You should also consider picking up some carbon monoxide detectors and a fire extinguisher or two as well—you can never be too careful when it comes to the multi-hundred-thousand-dollar chunk of personal property that you now own.

UPKEEP AND REPAIR

Even if you buy a brand-new home, something will break eventually. When we recently posed the question “What do you wish you knew before you bought your first house?” a fair number of people responded, “I wish I knew how much it would cost for upkeep and repairs.”

One respondent had an excellent idea. She suggested putting 1 percent of the purchase price of the home into an account every year. If you have extra left over after repairs each year, the fund will just keep growing—and that's more financial security backing your home purchase.

Your main systems are going to be the most expensive to repair or replace, so those need your regular attention. A little goes a very long way.

Look at your furnace to see what size filter you need and buy twelve of them at a time. Replace the filter the day you move in, then mark that day on your calendar every month so you replace the filter regularly. If you have air-conditioning, this unit will be located outside the home. It has a protective grill surrounding the unit to keep the air intake material from being damaged. The air intake material will get clogged with random